Policy 02 — Complaints Procedure and Alternative Dispute Resolution

Operator	[COMPANY NAME], trading as PlayStake
Owner	[COMPLIANCE LEAD NAME], Complaints Manager
ADR provider	IBAS — Independent Betting Adjudication Service (www.ibas-uk.com). *Agreement to be signed before submission.*
Version	0.1 — draft for licence application
Review	Annually, and on any change of ADR provider (a key event to notify to the Commission)
Relates to	LCCP social responsibility code 6.1.1 (complaints and disputes) and the ADR requirements; the Alternative Dispute Resolution for Consumer Disputes Regulations 2015

> Draft for review by a compliance adviser. IBAS referral terms (including the time limit for referral) must be confirmed with IBAS when the agreement is signed.

1. Purpose

Customers must be able to complain easily, get a fair and timely answer, and take the complaint to an independent body if they are not satisfied. This policy explains how PlayStake makes that happen, and how the platform supports it.

2. What counts as a complaint

A **complaint** is any expression of dissatisfaction with PlayStake, whether spoken or written. That includes complaints about:

- the account, deposits or withdrawals
- a bet or its result
- a referee
- responsible-play tools
- how we have treated the customer
- how we handled an earlier dispute

A **result dispute** is a narrower, faster process. A player uses the dispute button on a bet to challenge a result before it pays out:

- **Timing:** within 24 hours of the result, or within 15 minutes of a referee's decision.
- **Effect:** payout pauses while staff review the game data, stream footage and referee evidence.

A customer unhappy with a dispute outcome can then make a complaint. Anything that is not a simple result challenge is handled as a complaint from the start. If in doubt, staff treat it as a complaint.

3. How customers complain

Customers can complain in two ways:

- **Online:** through the complaint form at **playstake.org/complaints**. It works whether or not the customer is signed in, so someone locked out of their account can still use it.
- **By email:** to **admin@playstake.org** (the address is shown on the complaints page, in the footer, in the Terms of Service and on every email). Staff log each email complaint into the complaints system on the day it arrives.

The /complaints page explains, in plain English:

- how to complain
- what happens next and when
- the 8-week deadline
- how to take the complaint to IBAS, and that IBAS is free and independent
- how complaints relate to result disputes
- other organisations: the Gambling Commission (which cannot resolve individual complaints), the ICO for data protection, and GamCare for support

It is linked from the site footer, from the Terms of Service (sections 09 and 17) and from every complaint email.

4. How complaints are handled

Stage	What happens	Timescale	How the platform supports it
1. Received	Complaint recorded with a unique reference (**PS-C-YYYY-NNNNNN**), a category, and any linked bet (only a bet the customer was in can be linked).	Immediately	A database sequence issues references, so two complaints can never share one.
2. Acknowledged	The customer is emailed their reference, the date by which they will get a final response, and how to reach IBAS.	Immediately	Automatic acknowledgement email.
3. Investigated	A handler reviews the complaint and relevant records, and asks the customer for more information if needed. Internal notes and messages to the customer are recorded against the complaint.	As soon as possible	Staff queue at /admin/complaints, sorted by deadline. Overdue complaints are flagged in red, and those due within 14 days in amber.
4. Final response	A written decision (upheld, partially upheld, or not upheld) with the reasons, and what will be done to put things right. The letter explains how to refer the complaint to IBAS if the customer is not satisfied.	**Within 8 weeks** of receipt	The final-response email always includes the IBAS referral wording and link. Once it is issued, the complaint is locked.

Deadline alerts. The compliance inbox receives an alert when a complaint is 2 weeks from its 8-week deadline, and again if the deadline passes without a final response.

Accountability. Every staff action on a complaint is recorded in the append-only admin audit log: the note, message, status change or final response, and who made it.

5. Handling standards

- **Be fair.** Decide on the evidence, not on who the customer is or how they complained.
- **Keep money safe.** Where a bet or balance is involved, the funds stay protected while the complaint is investigated.
- **Be plain.** Write in clear English. Explain the reasons, not just the outcome.
- **Put it right.** If we got something wrong, correct it (including any money owed) and say what we will change.
- **Watch for harm.** If a complaint suggests the customer may be experiencing gambling harm, refer it to the Safer Gambling Lead and record a customer interaction (Policy 05).
- **Watch for crime.** If a complaint reveals suspected fraud or money laundering, refer it to the MLRO. Do not tip off the customer (Policy 07).

6. Alternative Dispute Resolution — IBAS

PlayStake's ADR provider is **IBAS**, the Independent Betting Adjudication Service. It is approved by the Gambling Commission as an ADR entity for gambling disputes.

- **When customers can refer:** once they have our final response and are not satisfied, or if we have not given a final response within 8 weeks.
- **Cost:** IBAS is free for customers.
- **Time limit:** customers should refer within six months of our final response. *This is the period stated on the site and in our emails; it must be confirmed against IBAS's terms when the agreement is signed.*
- **Where we tell customers about IBAS:** on the /complaints page, in the Terms of Service, in the acknowledgement email, and in every final-response email.
- **Our commitment:** PlayStake cooperates fully with IBAS, provides the records it asks for promptly, and complies with its decisions. *Confirm the binding nature of decisions against the IBAS agreement.*
- **Changing provider:** any change of ADR provider will be notified to the Commission as a key event, and the site and emails updated first.

7. Records and reporting

- **What is kept:** each complaint, its full history, the final response and the outcome. These are kept for at least 5 years and are not deleted with the customer's account.
- **Regulatory returns:** complaint volumes, categories, outcomes, timeliness and IBAS referrals are included in the Commission's regulatory returns.
- **Board reporting:** the same figures go into the quarterly board compliance report.

- **Trend review:** the Complaints Manager reviews complaint trends each quarter and feeds lessons into product and policy changes.

8. Review

Version	Date	Change
0.1	30 September 2026	First draft